

Support the patient with 'Long COVID' to manage his/her symptoms at home

- Explain that symptoms may differ between patients (no typical presentation) and may vary from day to day. S/he may find normal activities difficult (like washing/dressing/doing housework).
- Invite patient to look at the below and help him/her to choose lifestyle changes that may help to manage his/her symptoms. Explore what might hinder or support this.

Pace yourself, plan and prioritise tasks

- Build a regular routine. Plan each day so important tasks are done first.
- Avoid overdoing things on a good day. This may cause exhaustion the next day.
- Allow enough time to complete activities and to rest in between. Break tasks down into smaller ones.
- Ask others to help with the less important tasks. Think about how others can help you save your energy, like helping with groceries, cleaning and cooking.

Keep a diary to track improvement

Learn your patterns: learn what brings on utter exhaustion or other symptoms, and try to avoid these.



Get enough sleep

- Tiredness feels much worse if sleep patterns are disturbed. If difficulty sleeping:
 - Establish a routine: try to get up at the same time each day (even if tired) and go to bed the same time every evening. Avoid day time napping if able.
 - Avoid caffeine and smoking for several hours before bedtime.
 - Allow time to unwind/relax before bed.
 - Use bed only for sleeping and sex.
 - Once in bed, avoid clock-watching. If not asleep after 20 minutes, do a low energy activity (read a book, walk around house). Once tired, return to bed.



Keep active

- Start with light exercise (walking) for around 4-6 weeks. Gradually increase intensity to aim for 150 minutes per week (moderate intensity - working in garden). Monitor immediate symptoms (like fatigue/breathlessness) as well as delayed symptoms and adapt as needed.
- Before returning to sport, ensure you are able to complete activities of daily living and walk 500m on the flat without excessive fatigue or breathlessness. Ensure you have at least 10 days' rest and be symptom-free for a minimum of 7 days before starting.



Eat well

- Where possible, eat regular healthy meals that include fruit and vegetables.
- Drink plenty of water.
- Limit alcohol and caffeine.



Look after your mental health

- Find time to relax: relaxing activities can help sleep and mental well-being- try deep breathing exercises, yoga, reading or having a relaxing bath or shower.
- Find a creative or fun activity that you enjoy.
- Set small achievable goals that will give you a sense of accomplishment.
- Stay connected: spend time with supportive family and friends.
- Talk to your family/family or friends: share/explain the impact that symptoms are having on your life. It can be hard for them to understand.



Get help when you need it

- Discuss your worries with someone you trust. Join a support group, if available.
- Consider speaking to your employer about options to return to work more slowly.
- If you have financial worries, arrange to see a social worker.



Help the patient to manage ongoing breathlessness and cough

• Advise patient to do the following when feeling breathless:

- Stay calm, relax your neck and shoulders and choose a position that eases your work of breathing (see pictures). Think about your breathing: breathe in slowly through your nose, as if you are smelling roses. Breathe out through your mouth, pursing your lips as if you are blowing out a candle and try to relax rather than forcing it. Slowly count to 2 when inhaling and 3 counts during relaxation.
- Wipe a cool wet cloth over your nose and cheeks, this can help to relieve the feeling of breathlessness.



- Sit on a chair and lean forward with elbows resting on knees.



- Lean forward with elbows resting on the back of a chair.



- Lean forward with hands resting on knees.



- Lean against a wall for support and rest your hand on your thigh or tuck your hand into your pocket.

• Advise the patient with ongoing dry cough:

- Avoid breathing through your mouth as dry air irritates the airways and causes a cough. Try to interrupt cough cycle by closing your mouth, swallowing repeatedly and gently breathing through your nose until the urge to cough goes away. Sip drinks regularly (hot or cold). Suck boiled sweets or lozenges.

• If productive cough, arrange physiotherapist for further techniques.